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AI Overview



The native macOS `cp` command **cannot copy Unix domain sockets**. If you attempt to copy a socket file using `cp`, the command will either skip the socket, fail with an error, or create an empty, broken regular file instead of a functioning socket. Server Fault +3

Unix domain sockets are transient communication endpoints tied directly to running processes; they are not standard data files and cannot be duplicated to function elsewhere while maintaining their active connection state. Stack Overflow +1

If you are duplicating a directory structure containing sockets (such as a database runtime folder or temporary caches), choose one of the alternative methods outlined below. Macworld

Recommended Alternatives

- **Excluding Sockets via `rsync` (Best Practice):**

If you only need to copy the data files and prefer to let your applications recreate their own sockets naturally, use `rsync` to exclude sockets using the `--exclude` flag:

bash

```
rsync -av --exclude='*.sock' /path/to/source/ /path/to/destination/
```

Use code with caution.



- **Recreating Socket Files Manually:**

If you specifically require an empty, standalone Unix domain socket placeholder to exist in the target directory (without an active process backend), you can recreate it from scratch rather than trying to copy it. You can do this using a quick Python script or the `nc` (netcat) command:

bash

```
python3 -c "import socket; s = socket.socket(socket.AF_UNIX, socket.SOCK
```

Use code with caution.



Alternatively, using netcat:

bash

```
nc -U -l /path/to/destination/file.sock &
```

Use code with caution.

- **Using `tar` to Preserve the File Type Structure:**

If your system requires preserving the directory layout and file metadata intact, archiving the folder via `tar` will preserve the local socket file type marker (marked with an `s` in `ls -l` outputs). Keep in mind that doing this does not copy the active network connection state:

bash

```
tar -cf - -C /path/to/source . | tar -xf - -C /path/to/destination
```

Use code with caution.

If you are running into specific application errors while copying, let me know **which application generated the socket** or **what type of error message** you see so I can provide a targeted fix.



5 sites

MacOS cannot copy "special" files...they are marked with "s"

May 14, 2021 — Note that a plain `cp` copies file contents, but with the option `-R` or `-a`, `cp` should copy special files such as sockets. You can us...



Stack Exchange

How can I make a copy of device/socket file - Stack Overflow

Dec 7, 2010 — Found out the major and minor number of the device file you need to copy then use `mknod` to create the device file with the same ma...



Stack Overflow

not able to copy socket/inode file - Server Fault

Jul 12, 2013 — You cannot create it, but you can copy from a working system as below to some shared location between the machines and copy from t...



Server Fault

CP Command: Copy files in macOS - SS64

Syntax `cp [-R [-H | -L | -P]] [-fi | -n] [-pvX] Source_file Target_file` `cp [-R [-H | -L | -P]] [-fi | -n] [-pvX] Source_file(s) Ta...`

● SS64 Command line reference

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Macworld

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SS64 Command line reference · <https://ss64.com> › mac › cp

CP Command: Copy files in macOS

Copy the folder and subtree (recursive). If source_file designates a **directory**, **cp** copies the **directory** and the entire subtree connected at that point.

Missing: ~~sockets~~ | Show results with: [sockets](#)



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MacOS cannot copy "special" files...they are marked with "s"

May 14, 2021 — Their permission scheme is srwxr-xr-x. I can't copy them, as I get the following error message. `cp: cannot create special file '/Volumes/Samsung_T5/Dockers/vms ...`

[2 answers](#) · Top answer: This is a (s)ocket type file. As such, it doesn't have any persistent data associ...

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Manage files in Terminal on Mac

Use the cp command to make a copy of a file. For example, to copy a folder named Expenses in your Documents folder to another volume named Data: % cp -R ...

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Stack Overflow · 5 answers · 15 years ago

How can I make a copy of device/socket file

I can know inode of device/socket with stat, so seems like I can somehow "copy" this file for backup. Of course the solution is "dd", but I have no idea ...

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8:04

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4 key moments in this video



How to copy files using terminal on a Mac

YouTube · MasteringProgramming

1:26

Jun 6, 2022

To **copy** a file in the Mac terminal, use the **command "cp"** followed by the file name and the path of the destination folder.



2:51

Mac OS Terminal - cp

YouTube · Jbyte

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How to copy and move files through Terminal

Jul 6, 2022 — **Copying files with the cp command is simple.** First, launch Terminal (in your / Applications/Utilities folder). Then, use the following syntax to ...

Hexnode · <https://www.hexnode.com> › Home › Mac

Script to copy files and folders on macOS

The cp command **copies the content of a source file to the target file**. The -R option allows you to copy a directory and all its subfolders.

MacMost.com · <https://macmost.com> › using-terminal-to-copy-files

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an existing file, the file is overwritten.

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